OTTERLO, NETHERLANDS

Kröller-Müller Museum: Masterpieces

Colour, dots and drawn lines take different routes towards a recognisable image.



Van Gogh's café is recognisably a place before it becomes an argument about yellow and blue. Mondrian's clustered lines offer no comparable street to enter. Between them, this selection contains several ways for painted marks to become a figure or a landscape, and several ways for that recognition to remain incomplete.

Follow the edges of things. Seurat builds solid-looking forms from small touches; Redon sometimes lets a head or legendary scene emerge without closing every boundary; Toorop extends the body's contours into elaborate surroundings. These are not stages in a single march away from realism. Each produces a different balance between the pictured subject and the surface carrying it.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/kroller-muller-museum

The selection · 20

1. The Three Brides
   Jan Toorop · 1893
2. Terrace of a Café at Night
   Vincent van Gogh · c. 16 September 1888
3. The Laureate Head
   Odilon Redon · c. 1875
4. Woman with a Yellow Bodice
   Odilon Redon · c. 1899
5. The Langlois Bridge at Arles
   Vincent van Gogh · mid-March 1888
6. Composition in Line, Second State
   Piet Mondrian · 1916–1917
7. Geometrical Still Life I
   Georges Valmier · 1919
8. Hamlet in the Snow
   William Degouve de Nuncques · 1911
9. Landscape with Wheat Sheaves and Rising Moon
   Vincent van Gogh · 1889
10. Fishermen in the Var
    Henri-Edmond Cross · c. 1898
11. Sorrowing Old Man, At Eternity's Gate
    Vincent van Gogh · May 1890
12. Still Life
    Jan Treck · c. 1640
13. Woman Mending Stockings
    Vincent van Gogh · 1881
14. The Blind House
    William Degouve de Nuncques · 1892
15. April
    Maurice Denis · 1892
16. Le Chahut
    Georges Seurat · 1889-1890
17. Dancers
    Theo van Doesburg · 1916
18. Fatality
    Jan Toorop · 1893
19. The Channel at Gravelines, Looking towards the Sea
    Georges Seurat · 1890
20. Roger and Angelica
    Odilon Redon · c. 1909

01 / 20

The Three Brides

Jan Toorop

1893 · Oil on canvas · Kröller-Müller Museum



Jan Toorop. The Three Brides. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/jan-toorop/the-three-fiancees · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Toorop's curving lines do more than fill the spaces between the figures. They extend the bodies' rhythms into a shared, tightly worked environment, making it difficult to isolate a person from the pattern around her. The title names a relationship, but it does not resolve every encounter. Begin with where the contours connect and where they keep figures apart.

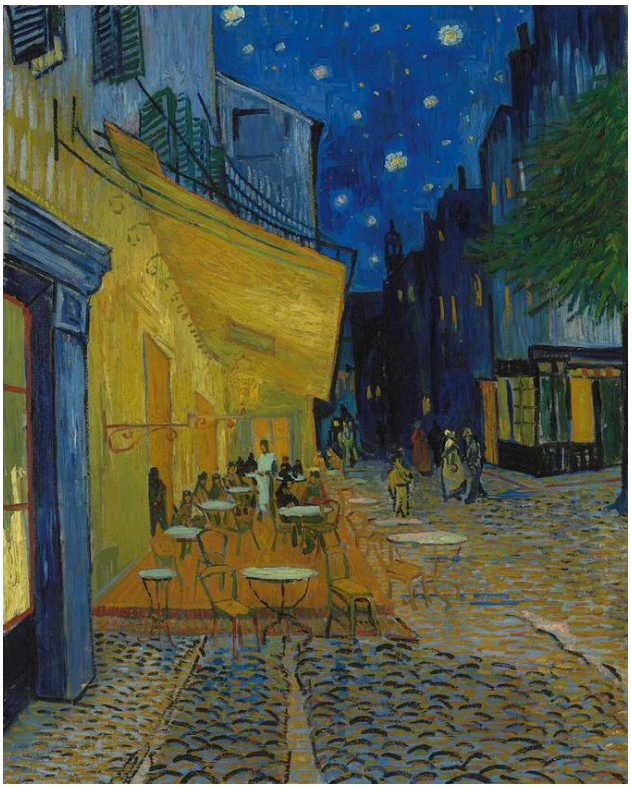
Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

Terrace of a Café at Night

Vincent van Gogh

c. 16 September 1888 · Oil on canvas · Kröller-Müller Museum



Vincent van Gogh. Terrace of a Café at Night (Place du Forum). Image credit: Vincent van Gogh; Source credit: https://data.collectienederland.nl/page/aggregation/kroller-muller/44529. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The yellow terrace does not simply stand out against the blue night; each colour makes the other more insistent. Van Gogh painted the gas-lit scene outdoors in darkness, according to the museum's account. The narrowing street gives the contrast a setting with depth. Night becomes a set of colour relationships rather than a dark layer applied over a daytime view.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KM 108.565

03 / 20

The Laureate Head

Odilon Redon

c. 1875 · Charcoal and pencil on paper · Kröller-Müller Museum



Odilon Redon. The laureate head. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/odilon-redon/the-laureate-head · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The wreath identifies a crowned profile, while the less certain neck and lower edge prevent the head from settling into a complete portrait. Redon grants solidity selectively. The image can suggest a sculptural object at one moment and an apparition at another because its boundaries offer different amounts of information. Completing it mentally remains part of looking.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Woman with a Yellow Bodice

Odilon Redon

c. 1899 · Pastel on paper · Kröller-Müller Museum



Odilon Redon. Woman with a Yellow Bodice. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/odilon-redon/woman-with-a-yellow-bodice · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The bodice claims attention more forcefully than the softly handled face. Redon does not distribute descriptive emphasis according to the expectation that every portrait must concentrate its sharpest effect in the features. The cool surroundings help the yellow establish the sitter's presence. Clothing supplies the broad statement; the face qualifies its brightness with a gentler register.

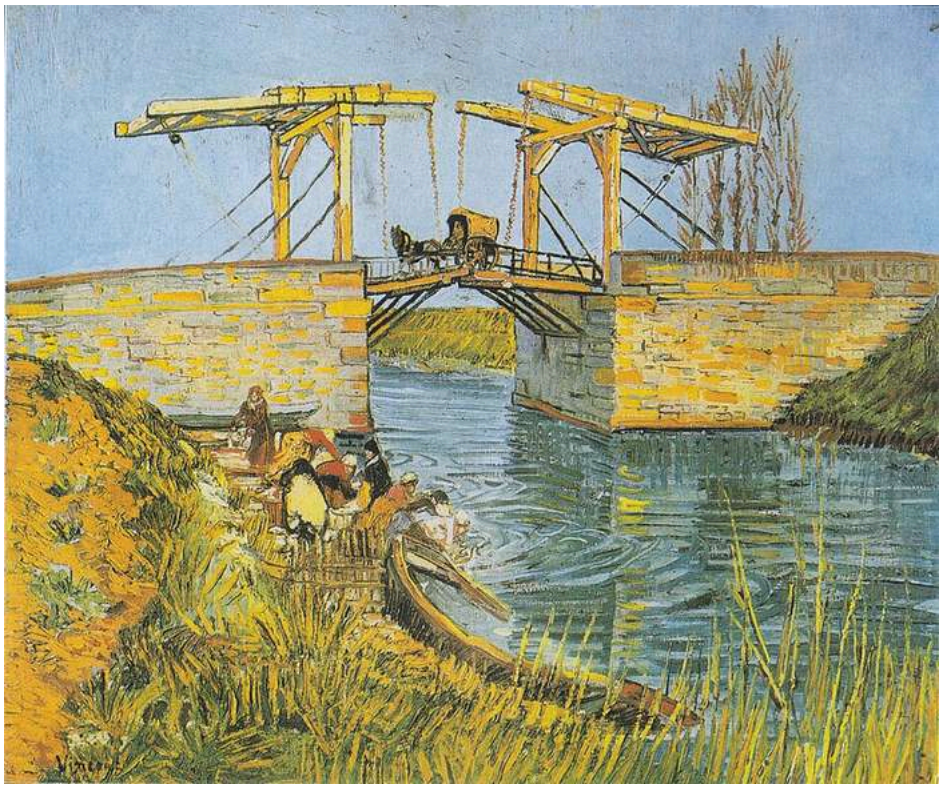
Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

The Langlois Bridge at Arles

Vincent van Gogh

mid-March 1888 · Oil on canvas · Kröller-Müller Museum



Vincent van Gogh. Bridge at Arles (Pont de Langlois). Image credit: Vincent van Gogh; Source credit: Copied from an art book. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The bridge's raised mechanism makes a readily grasped arrangement of angles. Below, water and reflections break that firmness into less stable marks. Van Gogh lets a working structure give the scene its geometry without requiring the whole landscape to obey it. Figures at the bank keep the crossing connected to activity rather than leaving it as an isolated engineering diagram.

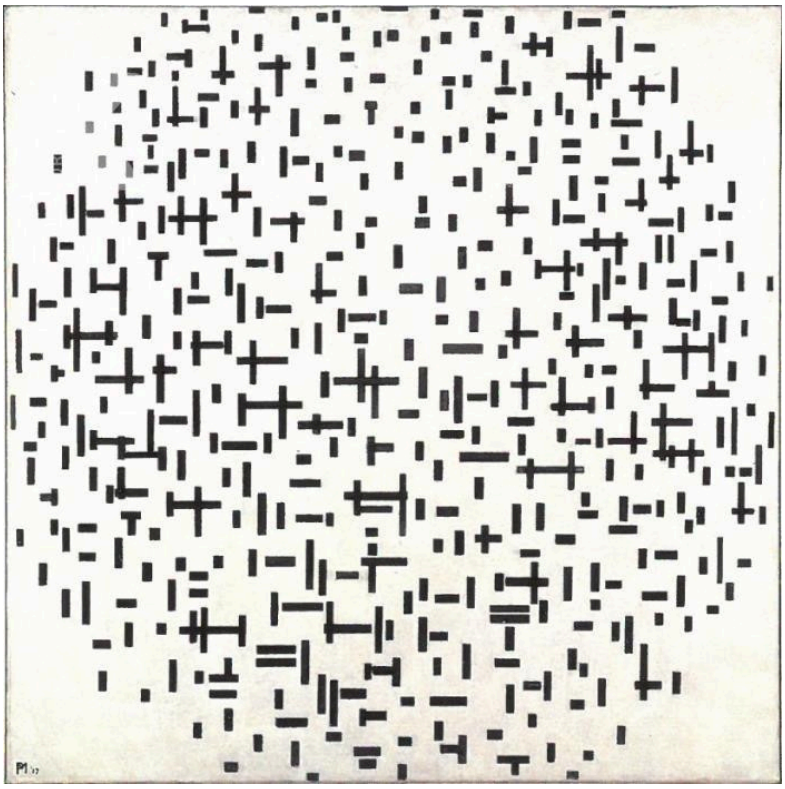
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KM 111.056

06 / 20

Composition in Line, Second State

Piet Mondrian

1916–1917 · Oil on canvas · Kröller-Müller Museum



Composition in line, second state. Wikimedia Commons; Piet Mondrian; reproduction from catalogue.pietmondrian.nl. Public domain (PD-Art). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression. · Public domain (PD-Art)

The available directions are few: upright and horizontal strokes within a pale oval. Yet changes of length, spacing and density prevent them from becoming a uniform mesh. Mondrian makes the relationships among marks sufficient to sustain attention. Instead of asking which object a stroke describes, compare the pressure of a crowded area with the openness near its edges.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KM 106.482

07 / 20

Geometrical Still Life I

Georges Valmier

1919 · Kröller-Müller Museum



Georges Valmier. Geometrical still life I. Image credit: Georges Valmier. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Recognisable fragments of vessels and a table coexist with shapes that assert the flat surface. Valmier withholds a single position from which everything could be seen together. The still life has to be assembled through connections rather than read as an uninterrupted view. Its broken organisation makes recognition a sequence of small decisions, not an instant identification of a familiar arrangement.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KM 103.852

08 / 20

Hamlet in the Snow

William Degouve de Nuncques

1911 · Kröller-Müller Museum



William Degouve de Nuncques. Hamlet in the Snow. Image credit: William Degouve de Nuncques. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The dark stream supplies a curving route through the repeated bare trunks. Low houses remain beyond this screen, so approaching the settlement is less straightforward than recognising it. Degouve de Nuncques makes the winter enclosure through the placement of ordinary landscape elements. The atmosphere can feel watchful without requiring a hidden occupant or a story the image does not provide.

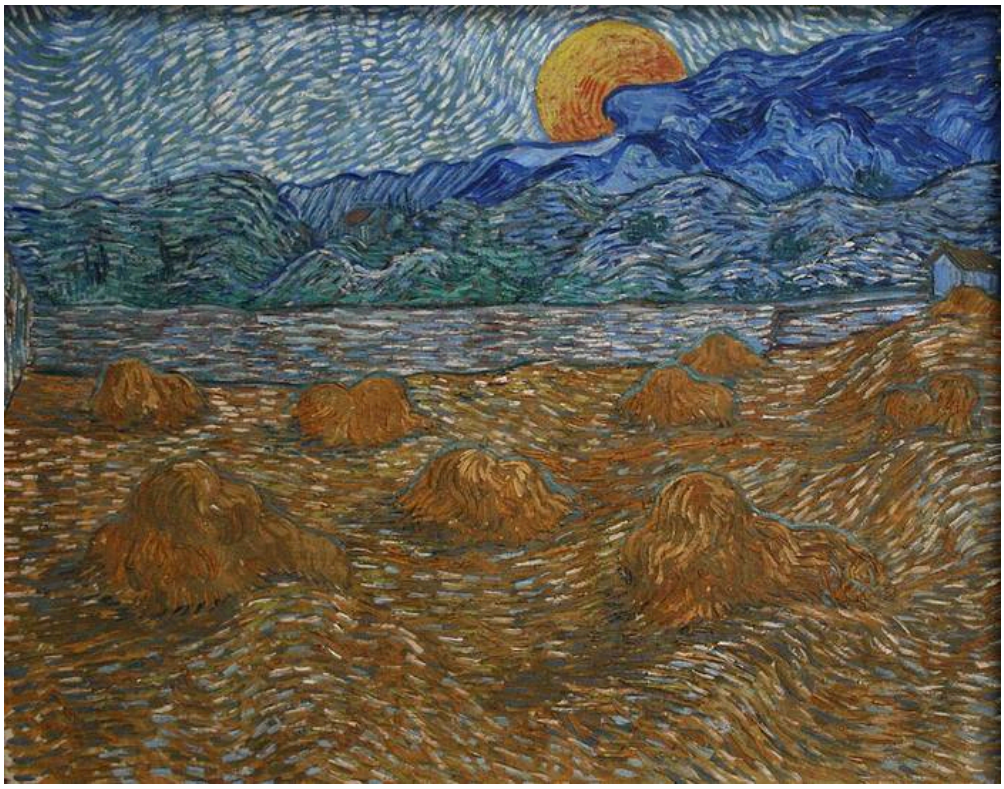
Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

Landscape with Wheat Sheaves and Rising Moon

Vincent van Gogh

1889 · Kröller-Müller Museum



Vincent van Gogh. Landscape with wheat sheaves and rising moon. Image credit: Vincent van Gogh; own photo in the Kröller-Müller museum. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Landscape_with_wheat_sheaves_and_rising_moon.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

Painted strokes change direction with the field, while the orange moon holds a comparatively simple shape above it. Van Gogh sets different kinds of movement against one another: the ground appears worked over, the circle remains steady. The harvested sheaves give that active surface recognisable contents. Colour and brush direction organise the landscape as firmly as its objects do.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KM 107.656

10 / 20

Fishermen in the Var

Henri-Edmond Cross

c. 1898 · Kröller-Müller Museum



Henri-Edmond Cross. Pêcheurs (Var). Image credit: Henri-Edmond Cross; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Henri-Edmond-Cross-Fisherman.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The bent figures, shore and bright sky share a surface of separated coloured touches. Cross therefore binds the workers to their setting through the way they are painted, even where their poses distinguish them. The sail provides a more legible shape among the dispersed marks. Labour belongs within the landscape's light instead of interrupting it as a separate anecdote.

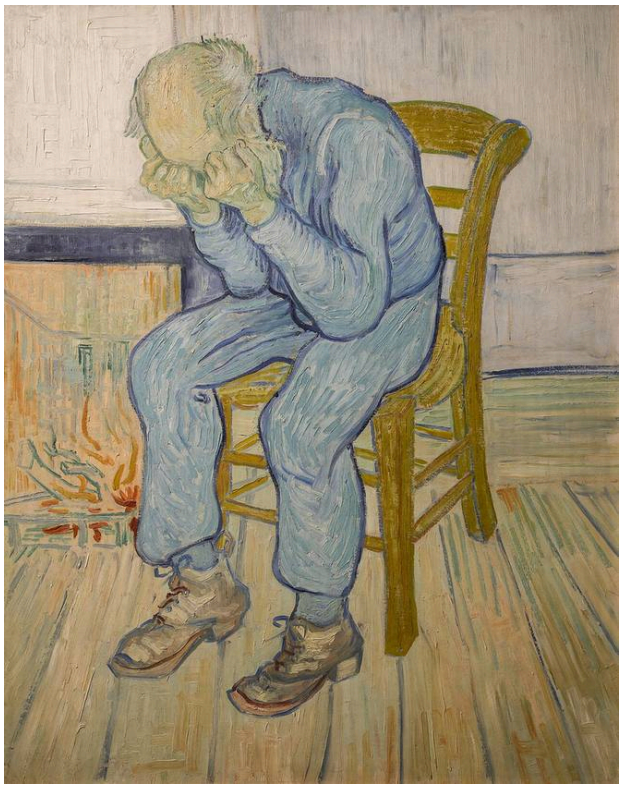
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KM 109.001

11 / 20

Sorrowing Old Man, At Eternity's Gate

Vincent van Gogh

May 1890 · Oil on canvas · Kröller-Müller Museum



Vincent van Gogh. Sorrowing Old Man ('At Eternity's Gate'). Image credit: GoldenArtists. CC BY-SA 4.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · CC BY-SA 4.0

Both hands cover the man's face, denying the expression usually expected to explain an emotional subject. The bent back and lowered head carry the burden instead, grounded by the seated body and planted feet. Van Gogh gives distress an unmistakable posture without specifying every cause. The missing face limits what can be said about this particular person's thoughts.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KM 111.041

12 / 20

Still Life

Jan Treck

c. 1640 · Kröller-Müller Museum



Jan Treck. Still Life circa 1640. Image credit: Jan Treck. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Small highlights separate the dark vessels, while the white cloth offers a continuous route among otherwise distinct objects. Its fall over the edge also establishes the table's depth. Jan Treck uses the cloth as more than a contrasting colour: it connects, divides and locates. The ordinary arrangement becomes readable through a carefully rationed supply of light.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KM 108.288

13 / 20

Woman Mending Stockings

Vincent van Gogh

1881 · Kröller-Müller Museum



Vincent van Gogh. Woman Mending Stockings. Image credit: Vincent van Gogh. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The task gathers attention around a small area of hands and dark stocking. Beneath it, the long skirt describes a larger, securely seated body. Van Gogh keeps these scales of activity together: a repeated movement at the fingers and the sustained posture necessary to support it. Domestic work acquires physical substance without needing to become a dramatic event.

Object source · Open artwork

14 / 20

The Blind House

William Degouve de Nuncques

1892 · Kröller-Müller Museum



William Degouve de Nuncques. The blind house. Image credit: William Degouve de Nuncques; Source credit: Kröller-Müller Museum. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The orange wall makes the house visible, but the dark trees and unresponsive-looking windows make it less accessible. Brightness does not necessarily produce welcome. Degouve de Nuncques establishes that contradiction through ordinary architectural features and their surroundings. The title sharpens the impression of a building that cannot return a gaze, while leaving its interior unavailable.

Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

April

Maurice Denis

1892 · Kröller-Müller Museum



Maurice Denis. April. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The pale figures recur across the green ground as separate presences and repeated colour shapes. Denis lets both readings remain available. The winding path suggests movement into a landscape, while flattened areas hold attention on its arrangement across the surface. Distance is present, but it does not require the picture's pattern to disappear behind an illusion of depth.

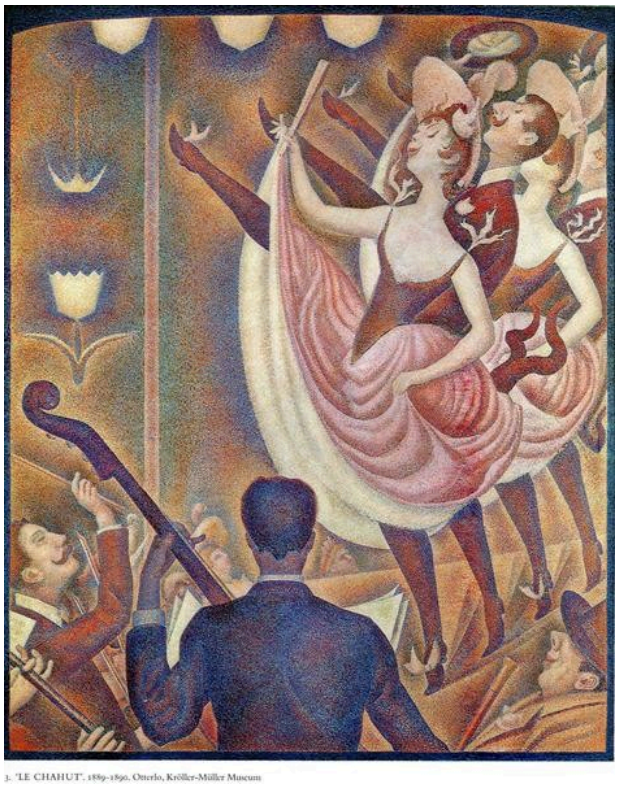
Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

Le Chahut

Georges Seurat

1889-1890 · Kröller-Müller Museum



Georges Seurat. Chahut. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Raised legs and upward-curving details repeat across the performance. Seurat builds the impression of exuberance from an exceptionally ordered arrangement, rather than from uncontrolled handling. The dancers move within a painted structure that continually echoes their gestures. The useful tension lies there: the spectacle appears lively because its directions have been coordinated so thoroughly.

Object source · Open artwork

17 / 20

Dancers

Theo van Doesburg

1916 · Kröller-Müller Museum



Theo van Doesburg. Dancers. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The two figures are constructed from geometric pieces, yet differences in the position of an arm or the balance of a shape remain enough to distinguish their gestures. Van Doesburg reduces anatomical information without eliminating bodily recognition. Compare the figures directly: small rearrangements have a large effect when the vocabulary of forms has become this economical.

Object source · Open artwork

18 / 20

Fatality

Jan Toorop

1893 · Kröller-Müller Museum



Jan Toorop. Fatality. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Flowing hair and enclosing lines make it difficult to locate a free space around the central figures. Toorop gives the abstract title a visible condition of entanglement. That does not supply a complete narrative key, but it offers a grounded beginning: the bodies belong to a pattern whose pressures extend beyond their individual gestures.

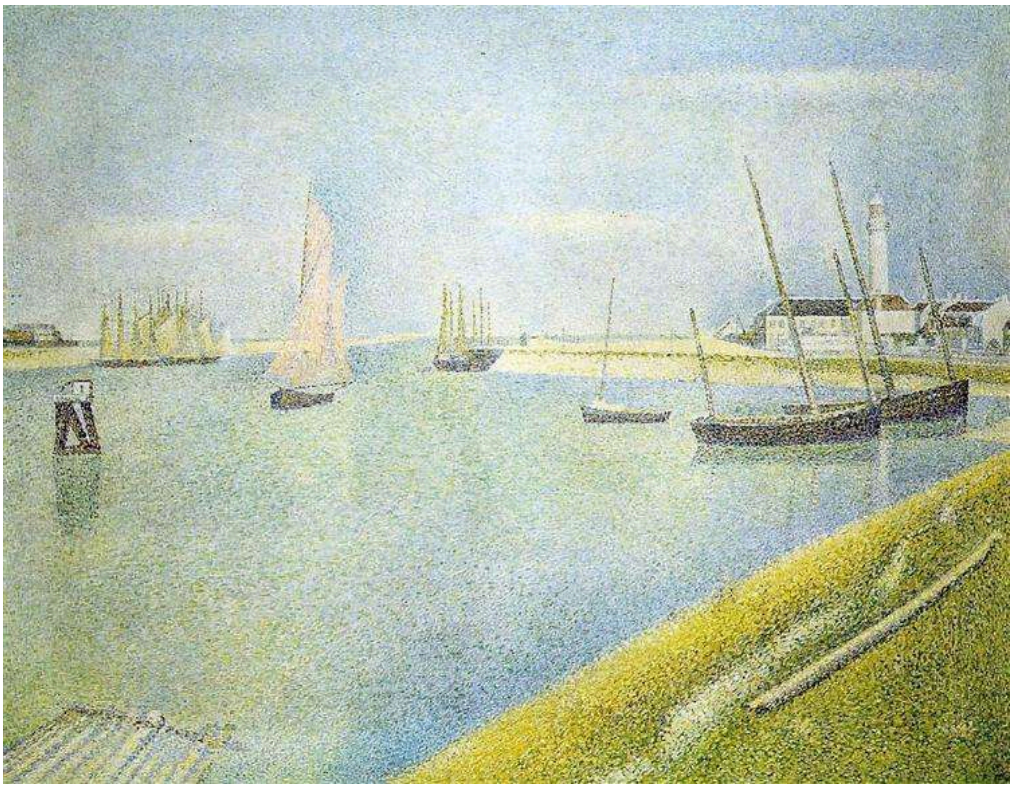
Object source · Open artwork

19 / 20

The Channel at Gravelines, Looking towards the Sea

Georges Seurat

1890 · Kröller-Müller Museum



Georges Seurat. The Channel at Gravelines, in the Direction of the Sea. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Masts rise from pale water while the bank establishes a long, stable division. The channel appears quiet even though the painted surface is made from numerous active touches. Seurat separates the movement of the subject from the activity of its construction. The marks need not become smooth for the boats and their setting to seem still.

Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

Roger and Angelica

Odilon Redon

c. 1909 · Kröller-Müller Museum



Odilon Redon. Roger and Angelica. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/odilon-redon/roger-and-angelica · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The mounted figure and winged creature emerge only partially from the coloured surroundings. Redon supplies enough information to suggest the legendary rescue without turning every passage into a clear narrative instruction. Blue, orange and gold retain a life beyond the objects they describe. The scene appears to be taking shape rather than merely waiting to be identified.

Object source · Open artwork

Change the distance

Compare a whole image with a detail whenever a good reproduction allows it. The subject may appear stable at one distance and dissolve into separate marks at another. This is a collection-based selection, not a promise of current display; check the museum's object records and visiting information before making a work the purpose of a trip.

Further reading

Vincent van Gogh: The Letters

Vincent van Gogh; edited by Leo Jansen, Hans Luijten and Nienke Bakker · Read free · English translations and original texts

Van Gogh's letters describe his working methods and his responses to other artists in detail. The scholarly online edition lets you search for the café terrace, the bridge at Arles and other subjects represented here.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

Artline · Kröller-Müller Museum: Masterpieces